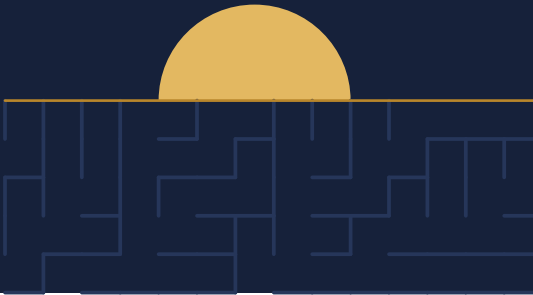


Untitled Horror Maze Game

Fear the dead end. Rely on it.

Version 1 · September 20, 2026
Concept stage, not yet prototyped · Goal undecided



0 Start here

The original conversations were deleted, so this document is the complete record: the current design, how it evolved, an assessment, the open decisions and a plan. To pick up where you left off, start a new chat, attach this PDF and paste the prompt below, filling in the last line.

RESUME PROMPT · COPY EVERYTHING INSIDE THE BOX

I'm designing a roguelite horror maze game. The attached PDF is the full design record and planning pack from earlier conversations that no longer exist, so treat it as our shared history.

Please read the whole PDF before replying. Section 2 (Current design) is the source of truth; if anything elsewhere disagrees with it, Section 2 wins. Section 3 records how the design evolved and which ideas came from me versus another AI (Gemini). Only items tagged DECIDED are my decisions. IDEA items are suggestions I haven't adopted, so don't treat them as settled.

In your first reply, don't summarize the document back to me. Instead:

1. In two or three sentences, confirm where the project stands.
2. List the open decisions from Section 5 that still need answers, most important first.
3. Ask what I want to work on today, unless I've said so below.

As we work, keep a running decision log (decision, my choice, date) that I can use to update this document, and point out whenever a new decision conflicts with an earlier one. Be honest and critical rather than just encouraging.

Today I want to work on: _____

Tags used in this document

DECIDED	You stated or confirmed it in one of the chats.
OPEN	Not decided yet. The matching decision in Section 5 is noted as D1, D2 and so on.
CHECK	Claude's reading of something you said. Confirm it's right.
IDEA	A suggestion from Gemini or Claude that you haven't adopted. The source is in brackets.
REJECTED	You considered it and turned it down.

Brackets show where each item came from. [Chat 1] and [Chat 3] are the Gemini conversations (Chat 2 was a cut-off duplicate of Chat 1); [Claude] marks the review done on September 20, 2026. To keep this record current as decisions are made, see Appendix D.

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1 Project snapshot

The pitch

A first-person roguelite survival horror game. You're dropped in the middle of a maze made of three separate worlds: a backrooms-style liminal space, a damp medieval dungeon or castle, and a mystical forest. Each world has its own monsters and a hidden objective (a lever, shrine, bell or similar) that a subtle signal guides you toward. Reaching a dead end throws you into one of the other worlds, so dead ends are both what you dread, because you lose your progress, and your main way out of a chase. Activating a world's objective sets off a collapse: every monster locks onto you, you get unlimited stamina and extra speed, and you have to find a dead end to escape, after which that world is gone for the rest of the run. A fourth, final map comes after the three. Between runs you spend a currency called sun dials on upgrades and items. Underneath it all, you're trapped in a simulation, and breaking it is the only way to see the real sky and sun again.

The thesis

Your stated goal from Chat 3: players should fear dead ends while exploring, turning around frustrated at the lost progress, and also rely on them as the mechanic they use to escape. Most horror games give you a threat and a separate escape tool; this one makes them the same object. Judge every system in this document by whether it serves that.

Where things stand

- Concept stage. The design is detailed on paper but, as far as the record shows, nothing has been prototyped.
- The newest version (Chat 3) is canonical. It differs from Chat 1 in fundamental ways, most importantly persistent maps instead of a maze that regenerates (Section 3.3).
- Seventeen decisions are open, two of them critical to the run structure (Section 5).
- The goal is undecided: fun and learning, a portfolio piece or a commercial release. The next steps are the same for all three.

Developer context

Computer systems engineering graduate, comfortable in C/C++ and Python from embedded systems work. Game development experience hasn't been recorded. No team has been mentioned, so the plan assumes a solo developer.

Next three moves

1. Answer the two critical decisions: what the last base map's dead ends do (D1) and what the final map is (D2).
2. Lock a short version 1 spec from Section 2.
3. Build the gray-box prototype of the swap (Section 6.2) and playtest it with three to five people.

2 Current design

This is the working spec and the source of truth. It follows Chat 3, the newest version, with Chat 1 decisions carried over wherever Chat 3 was silent. Undecided items point to their decision number in Section 5.

2.1 Premise and lore

DECIDED	The player is trapped in a simulation. Destroying the objectives (called reality anchors in Chat 1) breaks it, so the player can return to reality and see the sky and sun again. <i>[Chat 1]</i>
DECIDED	The maze is an entity that doesn't want to be closed, which is why it guards its objectives with dead ends. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
OPEN	How the simulation and the maze-entity fit together, and what explains an office, a castle and a fairy forest existing side by side. (D13)
IDEA	A living simulation that builds its worlds out of what it has absorbed and fights to keep itself running. <i>[Claude]</i>
IDEA	Lean on the sun-dial motif: a sundial is useless without the sun, so the currency itself tells the story. <i>[Claude]</i>

2.2 Run structure

DECIDED	The player starts in the middle of the maze. <i>[Chat 3; Chat 1 started at an entrance]</i>
DECIDED	Three base maps are generated at the start of each run and kept for the whole run, plus one final map. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	Maps include rooms as well as corridors. <i>[Chat 1]</i>
DECIDED	Each base map has one objective (a lever, shrine, button, bell or similar) with a signal that guides the player slightly. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	Activating an objective starts that map's collapse. Escaping it removes the map from the active pool, and dead ends can no longer send the player there. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	As maps are removed, monster frequency and sensitivity increase. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	A removed map's monsters start turning up in small numbers in the remaining maps; with one map left, all of them can appear there. <i>[Chat 3; first raised by Gemini in Chat 1]</i>
OPEN	What the last base map's dead ends do, since no other base map is left to send the player to. (D1)
OPEN	What the final map is, and how a winning run ends. (D2)

2.3 The maps

	Backrooms-style (“lab”)	Dungeon / castle	Mystical forest	Final map
Look	Liminal, backrooms-esque corridors	Damp medieval stone	Dark mystical woods	OPEN
Container	Locker	Traditional chest	Hollow mystical tree trunk	OPEN
Objective	OPEN · idea: main breaker	OPEN · idea: the great bell	Trample the fairy village	OPEN
Signal	OPEN	OPEN	Glow behind the trees	—
Monsters	OPEN · idea: shadow beast	OPEN · idea: blind witch	Gnomes, fairies	OPEN
Advantage	OPEN · idea: constant light	OPEN · idea: silence	OPEN · idea: fairy light	—

Plain entries are decided (Chats 1 and 3); the forest is the only map with a designed objective. Chat 1 called the three looks “biomes” and Chat 3 calls them maps; they’re the same thing.

IDEA	Atmosphere and senses per map: the backrooms’ buzzing fluorescent hum and damp carpet that muffles footsteps; the dungeon’s dripping water and hard echoes; the forest’s fake moonlight, rustling wind, and dead leaves and twigs that make noise. [Gemini, Chat 1]
IDEA	Make each map’s objective destroy its advantage. The backrooms’ constant light dies when you pull the main breaker; the dungeon’s silence, which lets you hear anything coming, shatters when you ring the great bell and tell everything where you are; the forest’s fairy light, which guides you, turns on you when you trample the village. [Claude]
IDEA	Pair monsters with those advantages: the shadow beast in the backrooms (manageable while the lights are on, deadly after the blackout) and the witch in the dungeon (audible in the silence, drawn by the bell). [Claude]
IDEA	Make the backrooms map an original liminal facility, closer to the “lab” you once described, so the game doesn’t read as another backrooms game. [Claude]

2.4 The Dead-End Trigger and navigation

DECIDED	Design goal: players fear dead ends while exploring (lost progress) and rely on them to escape chases. [Chat 3]
DECIDED	Reaching a dead end swaps the player to another active map. Maps are swapped, never deleted or regenerated, so returning to a map means the same layout and some knowledge carries over. [Chat 3; in Chat 1 every dead end regenerated the maze]
DECIDED	The trigger is sight-based, not touch-based: it fires when the dead-end wall covers about half the view or the player faces it directly. [Chat 3]
DECIDED	During a collapse, the player must hold their gaze on the dead end for one second. Players are usually fleeing, so the monster is behind them while they do. [Chat 3]
OPEN	Whether the trigger in normal play is instant or needs a short hold. (D3)
DECIDED	Environmental tells: subtle cues, such as dimming light or a narrowing corridor, warn that a path leads to a dead end. [Gemini idea, adopted in Chat 3]

DECIDED	The long walk: paths into dead ends are unusually long, so a wrong turn costs real time and a chase becomes a sprint down a hallway hoping it ends. <i>[Gemini idea, adopted in Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	Dead ends are denser near the objective, the maze protecting itself, so rushing at the signal gets the player thrown out and careful play is rewarded. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	Each map has landing spots (entrances) and dead ends (exits). Neither can serve as the other. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
CHECK	Six landing spots per base map: three for arrivals from each of the other two maps. On a swap, the destination map is picked at random, then one of its three landing spots for the origin map. (D16) <i>[Claude's reading of Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	The player arrives facing a wall that blends the origin map into the new one across several wall panels (for example, clean backrooms wall giving way to castle stone), then turns around to see the new map. These walls work as landmarks the player can learn. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	When the player leaves a map, its monsters return to their idle behavior; forest gnomes, for example, resume wandering with footsteps unique to them. No ambush waits at the dead end. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
OPEN	Whether dead ends hint at where they lead. (D4)
REJECTED	Swapping by touching the dead-end wall and turning around. <i>[Gemini, Chat 3]</i>
REJECTED	The dead-end wall morphing seamlessly into the next map. <i>[Gemini, Chat 3]</i>
REJECTED	Monsters waiting in ambush at the dead end. <i>[Chat 3]</i>

2.5 Objectives and the collapse

DECIDED	Each objective gives off a signal that guides the player slightly. In the forest, a glow behind the trees leads to the fairy village. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	Activating the objective starts the collapse (the "rushed state"): every monster locks onto the player's location. <i>[Chats 1 and 3]</i>
DECIDED	During the rush the player has unlimited stamina and increased speed. <i>[Chat 3; Chat 1 had unlimited stamina only]</i>
DECIDED	The map rearranges itself so dead ends are far from the objective, the reverse of normal, which makes any memorized dead end useless. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	To escape, the player finds a dead end and looks at it for one second. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	Escaping costs part of the bar semi-temporarily (the escape toll). <i>[Chats 1 and 3]</i>
DECIDED	After escaping there's a grace period before monsters turn hostile: time to look around and heal. <i>[Chats 1 and 3]</i>
OPEN	Size of the toll. Chat 1: 1% of the maximum bar for every second spent rushing, capped at 50%, recoverable with bandages or hospital kits. Chat 3: "a small portion." (D5)
OPEN	Grace period details. Chat 1: 10 seconds with no monster spawns. Chat 3: short, with monsters present but not yet hostile.
IDEA	Collapse visuals such as red emergency lighting in the backrooms or a blood moon in the forest. <i>[Gemini, Chat 1]</i>
IDEA	Late in a run, the remaining map glitches, mixing in pieces of removed maps (dungeon torches on office walls). <i>[Gemini, Chat 1]</i>
REJECTED	Navigating back to a remembered dead end during the collapse. Chat 3's rearrangement deliberately prevents it. <i>[Superseded Gemini idea, Chat 1]</i>

2.6 Health, stamina and movement

DECIDED	One unified health and stamina bar. At zero the player dies and the run ends. <i>[Chats 1 and 3]</i>
DECIDED	The bar slowly regenerates on its own and drains from sprinting, monster hits and other mechanics. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	Some interactions take a portion away semi-temporarily, until the map is cleared or items heal it. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
DECIDED	Bandages give minor healing; hospital kits give major healing. <i>[Chat 1]</i>
DECIDED	Movement modes: walk, sprint and crouch. <i>[Chat 3]</i>
OPEN	What crouching changes. (D6)
OPEN	Whether sprinting alone can take the bar to zero, and whether clearing a map heals earlier semi-temporary losses before the escape toll applies. (D17)
IDEA	Treat the bar as a fill and a ceiling. The fill drains from sprinting and hits and regenerates, acting as stamina; the ceiling drops from wounds and tolls and comes back only through items or a map clear, acting as health. <i>[Claude]</i>

Note: Gemini's Chat 1 summary described the rush toll as permanent for the run. That isn't what you said; you made it recoverable with bandages and hospital kits.

2.7 Monsters

Monster	Home map	Behavior	Status
Shadow beast	OPEN	Retreats when the player looks at it (and presumably closes in when they don't)	Behavior DECIDED <i>[Chat 1]</i>
Blind witch	OPEN	Hunts by sound	Behavior DECIDED <i>[Chat 1]</i>
Gnomes	Forest	Idle wandering with a distinctive, audible walk	DECIDED <i>[Chat 3]</i>
Fairies	Forest	Turn hostile when their village is trampled	Trigger DECIDED ; hostile behavior OPEN <i>[Chat 3]</i>

DECIDED	Each map has its own set of monsters that hunt in different ways. Idle reversion, bleed-over and rising sensitivity apply to all of them (Sections 2.2 and 2.4). <i>[Chat 3]</i>
OPEN	The backrooms and dungeon rosters, home maps for the shadow beast and the witch, and what the fairies do once hostile. (D8)
OPEN	Which monsters the silver arrow can kill.
OPEN	How monsters react to loud container noise: investigate the spot, or become more aggressive across the map. (D12)
IDEA	The "catch-22": walking backward to keep eyes on the shadow beast makes the player bump into things, and the noise draws the witch. <i>[Gemini, Chat 1]</i>
IDEA	Maps change how senses work: carpet muffles footsteps, stone echoes, forest twigs snap, and forest shadows make players think the shadow beast is everywhere. <i>[Gemini, Chat 1]</i>
IDEA	Tune the shadow beast so one glance pushes it back far enough to buy the one-second stare during a collapse; otherwise the two rules can make some escapes unwinnable. <i>[Claude]</i>

2.8 Items and inventory

Item	What it does	Status and notes
Compass	Points toward the way out	DECIDED [Chat 1] Now overlaps with the objective signals. IDEA point it at the nearest dead end instead [Claude] IDEA imprecise, or spins when monsters are near [Gemini]
Radar	When used, shows which directions monsters are in	DECIDED [Chat 1]
Flashlight	Lights paths and improves visibility	DECIDED [Chat 1] IDEA needs batteries; less useful under backrooms lighting [Gemini]
Silver arrow	Kills specific monsters	DECIDED [Chat 1] Which monsters: OPEN
Glass sword	Single use; deals heavy damage	DECIDED [Chat 1]
Bandage	Minor healing	DECIDED [Chat 1]
Hospital kit	Major healing	DECIDED [Chat 1]
Chalk	Marks walls; the marks last because maps persist	IDEA [Claude]
Map-entry item	A new item each time the player enters a map	OPEN (D9). IDEA first visit to each map only [Claude] IDEA items that vanish when you leave, fragments that combine, or items with a risk attached [Gemini, Chat 3]

DECIDED	Inventory is limited and can be expanded through upgrades. [Chat 1]
OPEN	Starting inventory size. (D11)
IDEA	When the inventory is full, the player has to drop something to pick up a new item. [Gemini, Chat 1]

2.9 Containers

DECIDED	Containers stay in the game alongside the shop. They can hold items the player hasn't unlocked yet and restock items already used, so every run feels different even if the player escapes with the same kit. [Chat 1]
DECIDED	They spawn with a percentage chance along paths and in rooms. [Chat 1]
DECIDED	Their look matches the map: a locker in the backrooms, a traditional chest in the dungeon, a mystical tree trunk in the forest. [Chat 1]
DECIDED	Opening one is instant. [Chat 1]
DECIDED	The sound of opening one depends on how many objectives have been activated. [Chat 1]
IDEA	Three sound tiers: a quiet click with none activated, a louder echo with one, a screeching tear with two. [Gemini, Chat 1]
OPEN	How monsters react to that noise. (D12)

2.10 Meta-progression

DECIDED	The currency is sun dials. <i>[Chat 1]</i>
DECIDED	Sun dials are earned through a run. Chat 1 specified staying alive, with bonuses for killing monsters and activating objectives; Chat 3 described the currency as based on progress. <i>[Chats 1 and 3]</i>
DECIDED	The first run starts with no items; the player goes in blind. <i>[Chat 1]</i>
DECIDED	Accomplishments unlock items, which can then be bought with sun dials and carried into runs. <i>[Chat 1]</i>
DECIDED	Upgrades include stamina and inventory space. <i>[Chat 1]</i>
OPEN	What's kept on death: that run's sun dials (including when dying mid-rush) and purchased items. (D7)
OPEN	How much income comes from time alive versus progress. (D10)
IDEA	Split the shop into permanent upgrades and per-run consumables. <i>[Gemini, Chat 1]</i>
IDEA	Reward maps cleared, objectives, kills and new ground covered, with at most a small, capped bonus for time, so hiding in a corner isn't the best strategy. <i>[Claude]</i>

The title is also open (D14); see Sections 3.6 and 4.7.

3 Discussion history

How the design got here: the sources, the order ideas appeared in, what changed, and which suggestions you accepted or turned down.

3.1 Sources

Source	What it covers
Chat 1 (Gemini)	The original concept and most systems: the shifting maze, three biomes, reality anchors, the lockdown and rush, the unified bar, sun dials, containers, a development roadmap, a summary titled "Project Paradigm Shift" and title ideas.
Chat 2 (Gemini)	An earlier, cut-off copy of Chat 1 that ends at the sun-dial pivot. Nothing unique.
Chat 3 (Gemini)	The newest version. It restarts from Chat 1's summary (its first message reuses that summary's wording) and refines it: persistent maps, a sight-based trigger, landing spots, the maze as an entity and a collapse that rearranges the map.
Claude review	September 20, 2026: a consolidated report and assessment, and this document.

3.2 How the idea evolved

Chat 1

1. Original pitch: the player starts at a maze entrance, and every time they hit a dead end and turn around, the maze has reconfigured, so it can never be memorized. Procedurally generated paths include rooms, and chests spawn with a percentage chance to help players find the way out. Items: compass, radar, flashlight, silver arrow, glass sword. Monsters: a shadow beast you must look at to drive away and a blind witch that hunts by sound.
2. Three maze designs (backrooms, damp medieval dungeon, forest). Any dead end can switch the maze into any of them.
3. The win condition didn't make sense to you. Gemini offered three options: Reality Anchors (one per biome; each activated anchor removes its biome, and after all three the maze freezes and an exit appears), Artifact Assembly (collect four fragments, then survive 60 seconds while a portal opens) and The Descent (three to five levels via trapdoors or elevators).
4. You chose Reality Anchors. Gemini described phases: three biomes (maximum instability), two (a removed biome's monsters crowd into the others), one (the maze stops shifting and starts glitching), then the exit.
5. Activating an anchor triggers a lockdown: the biome locks in its current state, monsters swarm, and the player must reach a dead end to swap out.
6. Unified health and stamina bar with bandages and hospital kits; the rushed state with endless running; a 10-second grace period; a toll of 1% per second of rushing, capped at 50% and recoverable with items.
7. Pivot to sun dials: the first run has no items, accomplishments unlock items you can buy, upgrades include stamina and inventory space, and sun dials come from staying alive, with bonuses for kills and anchors.
8. Chests came back alongside the shop, for items you haven't unlocked yet and for restocks, so runs feel different even with the same final kit.
9. Containers take a different form per biome (locker, chest, tree trunk), open instantly, and their sound depends on how many anchors are active.
10. You asked how to develop the game; Gemini gave a five-step roadmap (Section 3.7).

11. Gemini wrote an overview titled “Project Paradigm Shift.”
12. Lore: escape the simulation by destroying the anchors, return to reality and see the sky and sun. Two rounds of title ideas followed (Section 3.6).

Chat 3

1. Refined pitch: dropped in the middle of the maze; find a lever, shrine, button or bell to trigger the “level shatter”; each map has its own monsters and gives its own advantage; a removed map’s monsters bleed into the rest; the Dead-End Trigger doubles as the escape tool; the rush gives unlimited stamina at a cost; cleared maps leave the pool; three base maps plus a final map; monster frequency and sensitivity rise as maps are removed; items are found in maps and currency depends on progress.
2. Clarification: maps are swapped, not deleted, so returning to one means the same layout.
3. Each objective has a guiding signal, like the forest’s glow leading to a fairy village you trample, which turns the fairies hostile and triggers the end phase.
4. Two open struggles: keeping dead-end randomness from feeling frustrating (perhaps by tuning how often dead ends appear), and whether to give a new item on entering each map.
5. Gemini suggested telegraphing dead ends, an “AI director” for dead-end frequency, a glitch warning before swaps and variations on the map-entry item.
6. You stated the goal: players fear dead ends and rely on them.
7. Gemini proposed environmental tells, the long walk, a touch-and-turn trigger, directional teasing and state memory. You kept the tells and the long walk, replaced the trigger with a sight-based one, turned teasing into higher dead-end density near the objective, and had monsters return to idle when you leave.
8. You corrected that players usually run with their back to the monster, rejected seamless morphing transitions, designed the landing-spot system, described the maze as an entity protecting itself, and required a one-second look at the dead end during a collapse.
9. You added walk, sprint and crouch; slow bar regeneration; the map rearranging its dead ends after activation; semi-temporary losses; rush speed; the escape toll; and the grace period. Gemini asked how crouch works, which wasn’t answered.

3.3 What changed between Chat 1 and Chat 3

Topic	Chat 1	Chat 3 (current)
Start	Maze entrance	Middle of the maze
At a dead end	New layout, any biome	Swap to another map; layouts persist
Trigger	Hit it, turn around	Dead-end wall fills about half the view
Arrival	Same spot; the world changed behind you	Landing spot facing a blended wall
Objective	Reality Anchor per biome	Lever, shrine or bell, with a signal
After activating	Map freezes as it is; swarm	Swarm; dead ends move far away
Rush perks	Unlimited stamina	Unlimited stamina and extra speed
Rush cost	1% of max per second, cap 50%	“A small portion” on escape
Grace period	10 s, no spawns	Short; monsters not yet hostile
Endgame	Exit appears after 3 anchors	3 base maps plus a final map

Topic	Chat 1	Chat 3 (current)
Healing	Items	Items plus slow regeneration
Monsters	Shadow beast, blind witch	Per-map sets, bleed-over
Currency	Time alive plus kills and anchors	Based on run progress

3.4 Gemini's ideas and where they landed

Idea	Chat	Outcome
A compass that is imprecise or spins when monsters are near	1	Not decided
The shadow beast and witch "catch-22"	1	Not decided
Maps changing how senses work (carpet, echo, twigs) and how useful the flashlight is	1	Not decided
Win-condition options: anchors, artifact assembly, descent	1	Anchors adopted
A removed biome's monsters crowding into the others	1	Adopted as bleed-over (Chat 3)
The last biome glitching with pieces of removed ones	1	Not decided
Collapse visuals (red emergency lights, blood moon)	1	Not decided
Navigating back to a remembered dead end during the lockdown	1	Superseded by the Chat 3 rearrangement
Shop split into permanent upgrades and consumables	1	Not decided
Dropping an item to pick one up when the inventory is full	1	Not decided
Container sound tiers (click, echo, tear)	1	Principle adopted; tiers not decided
Five-step development roadmap	1	Reference (Section 3.7)
Title ideas	1	Not decided
Environmental tells before dead ends	3	Adopted
The long walk	3	Adopted
An "AI director" that raises dead-end frequency during chases	3	Not decided
A glitch warning before a swap	3	Not decided
Map-entry item variants (vanishing, fragments, risk attached)	3	Not decided
Paying for the rush with narrowed vision or lost currency	3	Not decided
Swapping by touching the wall and turning around	3	Rejected
Directional teasing near the objective	3	Adopted as denser dead ends near it
The dead-end wall morphing seamlessly into the next map	3	Rejected

Idea	Chat	Outcome
Monsters ambushing the player at the dead end	3	Rejected; idle reversion instead

3.5 Questions that were never answered

- What happens to gear when you die? (Chat 1)
- How big is the inventory? (Chat 1)
- How do monsters react to loud looting? (Chat 1)
- What's your game development experience? (Chat 1)
- Do you lose currency if you die during the rush? (Chat 3)
- What stops you landing right next to a patrolling monster? The grace period partly answers this. (Chat 3)
- How does crouching work? (Chat 3)

3.6 Title ideas

“Project Paradigm Shift” was only Gemini’s placeholder for its overview. Its title suggestions:

Group	Titles
System-style	Project Sundial, The Rendered Labyrinth, System: Eclipse, Null Geometry, Unanchored
Atmospheric	A Memory of the Sun, Skyless, The False Canopy, Until Daylight, Beneath the Artificial
Mechanic-driven	Dead End Override, 180 Degrees, Turn Around, Sever the Thread
Poetic: sky and sun	To Break the Sky, We Forgot the Daylight, Echoes of Dawn, The Walled Horizon, A Sky of Static
Poetic: sun dials and time	A Dial in the Dark, No Shadows Here, Hours Without Light, The Sunless Measure
Poetic: shifting reality	The Painted Firmament, Tethered to the Night, The Labyrinth's Final Breath, Where the Earth Shifts

Gemini’s favorites were Project Sundial, Skyless and Dead End Override in the first round, and To Break the Sky and A Dial in the Dark in the second. Nothing was chosen; see Section 4.7 for a shortlist and naming conflicts.

3.7 Gemini's development roadmap

1. Write a game design document and freeze the scope.
2. Choose an engine: Unreal Engine, Unity or Godot.
3. Build a gray-box prototype with plain shapes: the maze generator, the swap, and biome changes shown as wall colors.
4. Add core systems and AI: the unified bar, the rush penalty, placeholder monsters and the lockdown.
5. Add art and audio, using asset packs; sound carries most of the horror.

This plan predates Chat 3 (its prototype detects a 180° turn); Section 6 replaces it.

4 Assessment

Claude's review from September 20, 2026. It judges the Chat 3 design, with Chat 1 details where Chat 3 was silent.

4.1 Verdict

The core idea is good, and the central mechanic is genuinely distinctive. Its strongest asset is a single rule that creates both fear and hope. Most horror games give you a threat and a separate escape tool; this design makes them the same object, so every corridor carries a decision. Chat 3's version is clearly better than Chat 1's: it keeps the disorientation while letting knowledge matter, and its pieces explain each other. The maze guards its objective, so dead ends cluster there; the maze is breaking, so they scatter.

What's weaker is the state of the design rather than the concept. It's broad, partly contradictory, untested and much bigger than it looks. One caution about the source: Gemini called almost every idea brilliant, and it endorsed both removing the chests and bringing them back, so its enthusiasm wasn't really weighing options. Treat it as encouragement, not validation. For a mechanic like this, the real test is playing it.

4.2 What's strong

The dead end's double role is the heart of it. "Fear it and rely on it" is the thesis of the whole game, and every other system should be judged by whether it serves that.

The wall-to-wall swap is a great trick. You trigger it while staring at a wall and arrive staring at a wall, so the teleport happens in the one moment the player can't see anything, and turning around becomes the reveal. It's cheap to build and exactly the kind of thing horror runs on.

Persistence with landing spots adds strategy. Knowledge carries within a run, blended walls tell you where you came from, and the maze stays hostile without being random noise. Because swaps decide where you are, the order you clear the maps also changes from run to run on its own.

The difficulty has a story reason. The dead-end gradient, the inversion when the objective breaks, and the world shrinking while monsters pile into what's left are all escalation the fiction explains, which feels far better to a player than invisible number tweaks.

The rush works like a loan. Unlimited stamina now and a lower ceiling later is a strong horror trade: you take it in a panic and pay for it in the quiet afterward.

The monsters are rules, not just enemies. Sight, sound and audible patrols each demand a different response, which keeps encounters readable and makes combinations interesting once they start overlapping.

The fairy village is the best single moment in the design. To escape, you destroy something innocent and it turns on you. It's also a pattern worth repeating: each map gives you something, and its objective takes it away (see the ideas in Section 2.3).

The containers are tidy. Disguised per map, instant to open and louder as the maze degrades, they fit the escalation without adding complexity.

4.3 Problems and suggested fixes

The endgame has a gap (D1, D2). With one base map left, its dead ends have nowhere to send you. In Chat 1, Gemini had dead ends stop working on the last biome and an exit door appear at the end, which doesn't fit with escaping a collapse through a dead end. A cleaner version of that idea is sealing them: the cornered maze stops letting you leave, and the only working exits are the ones its final collapse creates, leading to the final map. That fits the lore and makes a natural climax, but it takes away the core mechanic in the hardest stretch, so it needs testing. The alternative is looping those dead ends back to the same map's landing spots. The final map itself, the payoff for the whole premise, is still undefined, and it may work best as a short hand-built finale rather than a procedural one.

Random destinations work against your own goal (D4). A dead end is meant to feel like a gamble, but a coin flip between two maps isn't a decision. Since landing spots show where you came from, dead ends could hint at where they lead, like a patch of moss in the stone or a strip of wallpaper at the seam. That turns the randomness into a choice (the dungeon or the forest?) and answers the first thing you were stuck on in Chat 3. The landing spot itself can stay random.

Accidental swaps would feel unfair (D3). "The wall covers half your view" in practice means being close to the end wall while facing it. If that fires instantly in normal play, players will lose progress to a camera glance rather than a decision, which reads as cheap rather than scary. A brief hold, well under the collapse's full second, or requiring the player to be in the last stretch of the dead end keeps every swap feeling chosen. A distance check plus a facing angle is also far easier to build and tune than measuring how much of the screen the wall fills.

The approach to the objective could become a loop. If dead ends cluster around it and fire easily, players may get ejected over and over. No dead-end wall should be visible from the objective itself, and something like the signal growing stronger each time you're thrown out would soften repeated failures. Persistence already helps, since the second approach is informed by the first.

The bar needs one rule set (D5, D17). Read together, the chats describe two layers: a fill that drains from sprinting and hits and slowly regenerates, and a ceiling that drops from wounds and the rush toll and comes back through items or a map clear. So the ceiling is effectively your health and the fill your stamina, which is a good model. Still open: can sprinting alone kill you, or does it stop at a floor? Does clearing a map heal old wounds before the escape toll applies? And Chat 1's per-second toll gave the rush a clock the flat version lacks, though with dead ends now far from the objective it could get large, so it needs tuning either way.

Paying for time alive rewards hiding (D10). Sun dials for surviving encourage camping in a corner, especially now that the bar regenerates. Chat 3's progress-based framing is better: reward maps cleared, objectives, kills and new ground covered, with at most a small, capped bonus for time.

The items need a pass for the new design (D9). The compass pointed to the way out, but objectives now have their own signals; aiming it at the nearest dead end would make it a crucial rush tool. With persistent maps, something like chalk for marking walls becomes a real strategy. And an item every time you enter a map will flood the player, since swaps happen constantly, so limiting it to the first visit to each map keeps it special.

The shadow beast clashes with the one-second stare (D8). In a collapse you face a dead end with monsters behind you, and if the beast only backs off while watched, you can't do both. That's a good tension as long as one glance pushes it back far enough to buy the second you need.

The identity needs one thread (D13). A simulation holding an office, a castle, gnomes, fairies, a witch and silver arrows needs one explanation, or it reads as a mashup; the maze-as-entity idea could carry it, and the sun-dial motif is already the right kind of glue. The backrooms look is also very crowded on Steam, so an original liminal facility, closer to the "lab" you described, would help the game stand apart.

Repetition will dull the scare. The turn-around reveal will be terrifying the first few times and routine by the fiftieth. The escalation you've designed helps, but this is the main thing to watch in playtests.

4.4 Where the project stands

This is a well-developed concept that, as far as the record shows, hasn't been prototyped yet. There's more detail on paper than most solo projects start with, but it was built in conversation with an AI that agreed with nearly everything, so it hasn't been stress-tested. Several foundational rules are undecided, the chats contradict each other in places, and the most important question, whether the swap is still tense the thirtieth time, can only be answered by playing it. The design has also reached the point where more ideas bring diminishing returns; the next real gains come from locking a version and building it.

4.5 Scope, goal and positioning

The full game is realistically a multi-year project for one person: three base maps plus a final map, each with its own art and audio; likely six to nine monsters with distinct AI and animation; a constrained procedural generator; persistence; items; and a shop. With a C/C++ and Python background, the programming is the part you're best equipped for. Monster AI here is mostly state machines reacting to sight and sound, familiar territory from embedded work. Art, animation, sound and tuning are the heavy lifts, and sound matters more than usual here, since the witch and the gnomes are defined by it.

The goal (fun, portfolio or commercial) doesn't need settling yet, because the next step is the same either way; Section 6.8 covers what changes afterward. If selling it becomes the aim, the hook is in your favor: "turn around and the world is different" is instantly clippable for streamers. The crowded backrooms space and the fact that the design is naturally single-player (co-op would break the per-player swap) are things to weigh, not dealbreakers.

4.6 Reference games worth studying

Game	Why it is relevant
Antichamber	Spaces that change when you turn around or look away.
Layers of Fear	Rooms that rearrange behind the player, used for scares.
The Exit 8	A looping corridor built entirely on noticing what changed.
Labyrinthine	Co-op horror set in procedurally generated mazes.
SCP – Containment Breach	Its statue moves only when unobserved, a close cousin of the shadow beast.

4.7 Title shortlist

Of the titles so far, To Break the Sky and A Dial in the Dark fit the final lore best. Check Steam and a web search before committing: Until Daylight is very close to Until Dawn, and Skyless and The Sunless Measure sit right next to Failbetter Games' Sunless Sea and Sunless Skies. A working title is fine until something is playable.

5 Open decisions

Everything still undecided, with the options on the table and Claude's suggested lean. Leans are starting points for discussion, not decisions. Critical items block the run structure; High items block the prototype. Start with D1 and D2, then D16, D3, D4, D5, D8 and D17.

ID	Decision	Options	Suggested lean	Priority
D1	What do the last base map's dead ends do?	Seal them, so only the exits its collapse creates work, leading to the final map · loop them back to the same map's landing spots · something else	Seal them; it fits the lore and makes a climax. Fall back to looping if playtests find it unfair.	Critical
D2	What is the final map, and how does a winning run end?	Hand-built finale · another procedural map · a pure ending sequence	A short hand-built finale that pays off the sky and sun.	Critical
D3	Is the normal-play trigger instant or held?	Instant at the half-view threshold · short hold · must also be in the last stretch of the dead end	A short hold (about 0.3 s) plus the last-stretch requirement.	High
D4	How is the destination map chosen?	Purely random · hinted on the dead-end wall · chosen by the player	Hinted; keep the landing spot random.	High
D5	Size and form of the escape toll	Per second of rushing (Chat 1: 1% per second, cap 50%) · a flat chunk (Chat 3) · a mix	Per second, with a lower rate or cap than Chat 1, tuned in playtests.	High
D6	What does crouching change?	Noise · speed · visibility · bar drain	Quieter, slower and harder to spot, with no extra drain.	Medium
D7	What's kept on death?	All of that run's sun dials · a share · none; purchased items kept or lost	Keep a share of that run's sun dials; lose purchased consumables; keep permanent upgrades.	Medium
D8	Dungeon and backrooms content, home maps for the shadow beast and witch, and hostile fairy behavior	See Section 2.3	Each objective destroys its map's advantage (breaker and light, bell and silence); shadow beast in the backrooms, witch in the dungeon.	High
D9	The map-entry item	Every arrival · first visit only · drop the idea	First visit to each map only.	Medium
D10	Where sun dials come from	Time alive · progress · a mix	Mostly progress, with a small capped time bonus.	Medium
D11	Starting inventory size	Any number of slots	Small (about three slots) so choices matter; upgrades expand it.	Low
D12	How monsters react to container noise	Investigate the spot · map-wide aggression	Investigate the spot, which is readable and fair; map-wide aggression only during a collapse.	Medium
D13	How the lore fits together	Simulation · living maze · both	Both: a living simulation that builds its worlds from what it has absorbed.	Low

ID	Decision	Options	Suggested lean	Priority
D14	Title	See Sections 3.6 and 4.7	Decide after the prototype; shortlist To Break the Sky and A Dial in the Dark.	Low
D15	Goal: fun, portfolio or commercial	One of the three, or undecided for now	Decide after the prototype; the next steps are the same for all three.	Low
D16	Confirm the landing-spot reading	Three landing spots per origin map, six per base map	Confirm or correct.	High
D17	Bar edge cases	Can sprinting alone kill? Does a map clear heal wounds before the toll?	Sprinting stops at a floor instead of killing; a clear heals earlier wounds, then applies the toll.	High

6 Planning pack

A plan for turning the design into something playable. Stages build on each other. The prototype (Stages 1 to 7) exists to answer one question: is the swap fun and readable? Nothing past Stage 7 is worth building until the answer is yes.

6.1 Roadmap

Stage	What to build	Done when	Size
0 Lock v1	Answer D1 to D5, D8, D16 and D17; write a spec of a few pages from Section 2.	Everything the prototype needs has an answer.	S
1 Engine spike	Pick an engine; get a first-person controller moving in a gray box; learn scenes, input and raycasts.	You can walk around a test level.	S–M
2 Maze generator	Seeded grid maze with rooms, dead-end tagging, braiding by distance to the objective, the long-walk rule and landing-spot alcoves, plus a debug view.	Two different maps generate from seeds, and the dead-end gradient is visible.	M
3 The swap	Facing trigger with a hold timer, both maps kept in memory, teleport to a landing spot, a two-color blended wall and the grace period.	You can swap back and forth, and returning maps are unchanged.	M
4 Bar and movement	Walk, sprint and crouch; fill and ceiling; regeneration and drain; bandage and hospital kit pickups.	The sprint trade-off is felt, and the bar is readable.	S
5 Objective and collapse	Objective with a signal, activation, rearrangement, rush buffs, the one-second stare, the toll, and the map leaving the pool.	The full loop works on two maps.	M
6 First monster	A sight-based chaser with a state machine, idle reversion and lock-on during a collapse.	Chases end in dead-end escapes without any scripting.	M–L
7 Playtest 1	Three to five people, no explanation, metrics logged (Section 6.6).	A keep, change and cut list is written.	S
8 Expand the core	Sound-based monster and noise system, third map, the last-map rule (D1) and a stub of the final map.	Playtest 2 is done.	L
9 Items and economy	Items, containers, inventory, sun dials and the shop.	Playtest 3 is done.	L
10 Vertical slice	Art and audio pass on one or two maps; decide the goal (D15).	A slice you'd be happy to show someone.	L

S, M and L are relative effort, not calendar time. The engine spike is the most variable stage, since it depends on how familiar the engine already is.

6.2 Prototype scope

In the prototype	Left out for now
• Two maps as flat-colored geometry, one color per map • Seeded maze generation with rooms and braiding • Simple dead-end tells, such as darker floors or dimmer light on dead-end branches • Landing spots with a two-color blended wall • The sight-based trigger with a hold timer, plus the one-second collapse version • Map persistence and the active pool • The unified bar (fill and ceiling) with walk, sprint and crouch • One objective per map with a visible signal, such as a light beam above the walls • The collapse: lock-on, rush buffs, rearrangement, toll and grace period • One sight-based monster with placeholder footstep audio • A debug overlay and an event log	• Final art, lighting and music • More than one monster type • Items beyond bandages and hospital kits • Sun dials, the shop and unlocks • The final map and the lore • Menus, settings and saving

6.3 Scope tiers

Tier	Contents	Purpose
Prototype	Everything in Section 6.2.	Prove the swap is fun and readable.
Vertical slice	Two or three maps, two or three monsters, the full loop, core items and containers, a basic shop and a first art and audio pass on one or two maps.	Show the game to others and decide the goal.
Full game	Three base maps plus the final map, the full monster roster (likely six to nine), all items, meta-progression, lore, audio, settings, saving, accessibility and performance work.	Ship it. Realistically a multi-year solo project.

6.4 Technical notes

Choosing an engine

Engine	Languages	Good for this game	Watch-outs
Godot	GDScript (reads like Python), C#, C++ via GDExtension	Fast iteration and a lightweight editor; free and open source; easy to keep several map scenes loaded at once.	3D lighting is less advanced than Unreal's; a smaller horror asset ecosystem.
Unreal Engine	C++ and Blueprints	The best lighting for horror and a large asset marketplace.	A heavy editor, slower iteration and a steep learning curve.
Unity	C#	The largest tutorial ecosystem; many recent indie horror hits were built with it.	C# rather than C++.

Suggested: start in Godot unless photoreal lighting is a must, in which case choose Unreal. Switching engines later is expensive, so pick once, and check each engine's current license terms before committing.

World and persistence

Keep every active map in memory for the whole run, each instanced as its own scene far from the others. A swap is then just moving the player and flipping some state, and persistence comes for free. Monsters in maps the player isn't in can be paused, since they're idle anyway.

Map data

A grid of cells with wall flags, plus tags: dead-end wall (with the direction it faces), landing spot (with its origin map), room, objective and container spawn points. Generate everything from a run seed so any bug can be reproduced.

Generating the maze

Build a perfect maze first; a recursive backtracker gives long, winding corridors, which suits the long walk. Carve rooms and place the objective, then braid: remove each dead end with a probability that rises with distance from the objective, so dead ends stay dense near it and thin out far away. Keep only dead-end branches longer than a minimum length. Then validate: the objective is reachable, no dead-end wall is visible from the objective itself, and landing spots never count as dead ends.

The collapse rearrangement

Run the same braiding pass with the weighting inverted: open up the dead ends near the objective and create new ones toward the edges, then re-check connectivity with a flood fill. Precompute this layout at the start of the run from the same seed to avoid a hitch, and only change cells the player can't currently see.

The trigger check

Each frame, for the dead end the player is in: if they're in its last stretch, within a set distance of the wall and facing it within a set angle, a hold timer counts up; otherwise it resets. The swap fires when the timer reaches the threshold (short in normal play, one second in a collapse). An optional raycast confirms nothing blocks the view.

The swap sequence

Pick the destination map (at random, or through hints), pick one of its landing spots for the origin map, place the player facing the blended wall, start the grace timer, set the old map's monsters to idle and crossfade the ambient sound.

Monster AI

One finite-state machine per monster type: idle or patrol, suspicious, chase, search, return. Senses feed it: a sight cone checked with raycasts, and hearing through noise events. The shadow beast inverts sight by checking whether it's inside the player's view. Two global modifiers sit on top: a sensitivity multiplier that rises as maps are removed, and a collapse override that puts every monster in the map into chase with the player's exact position.

Noise system

Every sound-making action emits an event with a position and a loudness: footsteps by movement mode and surface, containers (louder with each objective activated), items and environmental noise such as twigs. Monsters react to events within their hearing range. This one system drives the witch, container noise and crouching.

Tuning and debugging

Keep every number in one config file so playtest tweaks don't need code changes. Build a debug overlay (dead ends colored by distance to the objective, landing spots, monster states, the hold timer), a seed field, a "swap now" key and an event log that feeds the playtest metrics in Section 6.6.

6.5 Starting values for the prototype

Everything except the decided rows is a starting guess to tune in playtests, not a design decision.

Parameter	Starting value	Source
Collapse gaze hold	1.0 s	DECIDED (Chat 3)
Normal-play trigger hold	0.3 s	Placeholder (D3)
Trigger distance	Within 2 m of the dead-end wall	Placeholder
Trigger facing angle	Within 30° of facing the wall	Placeholder
Landing spots per base map	6 (3 per origin map)	CHECK (D16)
Grace period	10 s	Chat 1 value; Chat 3 didn't specify
Escape toll	1% of max per second of rushing, cap 50%	Chat 1 value (D5)
Rush speed boost	+25%	Placeholder
Bar regeneration	Refills to the ceiling in about 60 s at rest	Placeholder
Sprint drain	Empties a full bar in about 15 s	Placeholder
Monster hit	−25% fill; heavy hits also −10% ceiling	Placeholder
Bandage	+10% ceiling	Placeholder
Hospital kit	+40% ceiling and a full refill	Placeholder
Dead-end survival chance	80% near the objective, 20% far away	Placeholder
Minimum dead-end branch length	3 cells	Placeholder
Prototype maze size	20 × 20 cells per map	Placeholder
Sensitivity multiplier	×1.0 / ×1.25 / ×1.5 with 3 / 2 / 1 maps active	Placeholder
Bleed-over	About 25% of a removed map's monsters	Placeholder
Starting inventory	3 slots	Placeholder (D11)

At 1% per second, a 30-second rush costs 30% of the maximum bar. Now that dead ends move far from the objective, rushes will run long, so expect to lower this.

6.6 Playtest plan

Who and how

Three to five people, ideally including someone who doesn't usually play horror. Explain the controls and nothing else. Watch in person or record the screen, and stay quiet while they play.

Watch for

- Do they notice the environmental tells?
- How many swaps does it take before they understand that dead ends lead elsewhere?
- Do they ever swap by accident, or feel cheated by a swap?

- Do they start using dead ends on purpose to escape?
- Does the collapse feel like a climax?
- Do they read the blended walls as “this is where I came from”?
- Do they hide rather than explore?

Ask afterward

- When were you most afraid, and when did you feel safe?
- Did any swap feel unfair? Which one?
- What did the blended walls mean to you?
- What would you do differently on your next run?

Log automatically

- Swaps per minute, split into swaps during a chase and swaps without one
- Swaps within a few seconds of entering a dead-end branch with no chase (a proxy for accidents)
- Time to reach each objective, and how many times the player was ejected near it
- Rush length and the toll paid
- Deaths by cause
- Time spent standing still

The prototype passes if

- Players can explain the dead-end rule in their own words.
- Most sessions produce at least one narrow dead-end escape.
- Accidental swaps are rare.
- The turn-around reveal still gets a reaction after ten or more swaps.

6.7 Risk register

Risk	Why it matters	Mitigation	Link
The last base map has nowhere to send you	The core mechanic breaks in the final stretch.	Seal its dead ends or loop them; test both.	D1
The final map is undefined	It's the payoff for the whole premise.	A short hand-built finale.	D2
Random destinations feel arbitrary	A gamble needs information.	Hint the destination on the dead-end wall.	D4
Accidental swaps	Lost progress feels unfair instead of scary.	Hold timer, last-stretch rule and clear tells.	D3
Ejection loops near the objective	Repeated failure turns into frustration.	Validation rules, tuning and a signal that strengthens after each ejection.	—
Habituation	The reveal stops scaring.	Escalation and audio variety; watch it in every playtest.	—
Scope	Solo and multi-year at full size.	Prototype, then a vertical slice, then decide the goal.	D15

Risk	Why it matters	Mitigation	Link
Backrooms saturation	It reads as “another backrooms game.”	An original liminal facility, closer to the “lab.”	D8
Lore mashup	An office, a castle and fairies need one explanation.	A unifying premise.	D13
Hiding pays	Time-based income rewards camping.	Progress-based sun dials.	D10
Shadow beast versus the one-second stare	Some escapes become unwinnable.	Tune how far one glance pushes it back.	D8
Item inflation	Loot stops feeling special.	Give the map-entry item on the first visit only.	D9
Two-map ping-pong	With two maps left, every swap is predictable.	Accept it as relief, or vary the landing spots.	—

6.8 Paths by goal

Goal	What changes after the prototype
Fun or learning	Keep going as long as it's enjoyable; the prototype is already a win. Build whichever features you find most interesting next.
Portfolio	Aim for a polished vertical slice rather than the full game, and show the systems: a short write-up of the generator and the monster AI, debug visualizations and a gameplay video.
Commercial	Build the slice, then put up a store page early to start gathering wishlists. Build the trailer around the turn-around reveal, run public playtests, position the game as single-player and check the title for conflicts.

Appendices

A Glossary

Term	Meaning
Active pool	The base maps a dead end can still send you to. A map leaves the pool once you activate its objective and escape.
Blended wall	The wall you face when you arrive at a landing spot. It shifts from your old map's look to the new map's across several panels.
Bleed-over	Monsters from removed maps appearing in the remaining ones.
Braiding	Removing dead ends from a generated maze by opening them into loops (Section 6.4).
Collapse	The phase after activating an objective: monsters lock on, the map rearranges its dead ends, and the player gets unlimited stamina and extra speed. Also called the rushed state or lockdown.
Dead end	A map's exits. Facing one (the wall filling about half the view) fires the Dead-End Trigger and swaps you to another map.
Environmental tells	Subtle cues that a path leads to a dead end.
Escape toll	The semi-temporary bar loss after escaping a collapse.
Fill and ceiling	A proposed model for the unified bar: the fill is stamina, the ceiling is health (Section 2.6).
Grace period	The window after a swap before monsters turn hostile.
Idle reversion	Monsters returning to their idle behavior when you leave their map.
Landing spot	A map's entrances, where you arrive after a swap.
Long walk	The rule that dead-end branches are unusually long.
Objective	The lever, shrine, bell or similar that starts a map's collapse. Called a reality anchor in Chat 1.
Semi-temporary loss	Bar capacity lost until you heal with items or clear the map.
Signal	The cue that guides you toward a map's objective, like the forest's glow.
Sun dials	The currency earned in runs and spent between them.

B Design checklists

Use these when designing a new map, monster or item, so nothing important gets skipped.

A new map

- Look, lighting and soundscape
- The advantage it gives the player, and how its objective takes that away
- Objective and signal
- Collapse visuals and sounds
- Native monsters

- Container look
- Blended-wall look for arrivals from each other map
- Noisy surfaces and other hazards

A new monster

- Home map and primary sense
- Idle behavior and its signature sound
- What alerts it, and how it chases
- How the player counters it, and whether the silver arrow kills it
- How it behaves when it bleeds into other maps
- How it behaves during a collapse

A new item

- What problem it solves, and what it costs in inventory space
- Single use or reusable
- The noise it makes
- Where it comes from: the shop, containers or the map-entry reward
- How it interacts with dead ends and the collapse

C Decision log

Record decisions here as they're made (or keep the log in your next chat and paste it into a new version of this document).

Date	Decision (ID)	Choice	Notes

D Keeping this document current

When you make a decision, add it to the decision log (Appendix C), update Section 2, remove it from Section 5 and bump the version number on page 1. Asking the AI in your next chat to regenerate this PDF with the changes works well; keep the tag system so decisions stay separate from suggestions, and add a row to the changelog below.

Version	Date	Changes
1	September 20, 2026	Created from Gemini Chats 1 to 3 and a Claude review: current design, discussion history, assessment, open decisions and planning pack. The goal was recorded as undecided.